# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

**America’**s House of Representatives approved a bill that would force **TikTok**’s Chinese owner, ByteDance, to sell the app to an owner of another nationality. Otherwise it will face a ban in America, TikTok’s largest market. Regulators worry that **China** is using the app to gather Americans’ personal data. Moreover, because TikTok is increasingly a source of news, they fear that it could be used as a tool of propaganda. The bipartisan measure passed 352-65, although its fate in the Senate is uncertain.

**Vladimir Putin** warned the West that Russia was ready for a nuclear war “from a military-technical point of view”, and warned America against deploying troops to Ukraine. He said that a recent spate of Ukrainian drone attacks on Russian oil facilities was designed to disrupt Russia’s presidential “election”. That three-day vote, which begins on Friday, is guaranteed to hand Mr Putin another six years in power.

**Rishi Sunak**, Britain’s prime minister, plans to change the law to prevent foreign governments from owning British newspapers. The law would threaten the planned takeover of the **Telegraph Media Group**—owner of the *Spectator* and the *Telegraph* newspapers—by RedBird IMI, a firm backed by the Abu Dhabi government. The government announced the plan in a House of Lords debate.

**Geert Wilders**, whose anti-immigrant Freedom Party won the most votes in the **Dutch** election in November, appeared to take himself out of the running for prime minister. Mr Wilders, who is still struggling to form a coalition, suggested on X that he would abandon his bid since not all parties supported it. He said he wants the Netherlands to have a “right-wing cabinet”.

A **Ukrainian** drone strike caused a fire at the Ryazan oil refinery near Moscow, one of Russia's biggest crude-processing facilities. A site in the southern Rostov region was also hit. Both halted operations. Ukraine has stepped up its attacks on critical infrastructure in recent months. On Tuesday it launched strikes targeting energy sites in at least seven **Russian** regions.

The **European Parliament** passed the AI Act, a law on regulating artificial intelligence. The EU is the first influential regulator to approve a big law on AI. The rules will subject the most powerful **large language models**, including ChatGPT, to stricter rules, such as mandates to assess risks and to take measures to mitigate them. It will also ban most uses of real-time facial recognition.

A **Japanese** rocket launched by Space One exploded on its maiden voyage seconds after launch. The solid-fuelled *Kairos*, which was carrying a government intelligence satellite, lifted off from the Kii spaceport in the western part of the country. Space One had hoped to become the first private Japanese company to send a satellite into orbit.

**Figure of the day:** $152bn, the US trade deficit with Mexico in 2023, up 17% from 2022. Read the full story.

*In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.*

Photo: Getty Images

# TikTok v Congress

Last week a stern pop-up message interrupted American TikTokers' scrolling. "Congress is planning a total ban" of the short-video app, it warned users, urging them to call their representative to protect their "Constitutional right to free expression". On Wednesday the House of Representatives passed the bill in question, which was less a "total ban" (such efforts have faced legal challenges) than a requirement that TikTok be separated from its Chinese parent company, ByteDance.

Lawmakers have long fretted about the national-security threats TikTok may pose: both the data that the company may be collecting, and the potential for the app to spread propaganda on behalf of China's government. It is already barred on government devices.

President Joe Biden supports the new bill, but its fate in the Senate is uncertain. TikTok fans have reportedly flooded lawmakers' phone lines, emphasising how much time they spend on the app—which only emboldened those critics who believe Americans are being brainwashed.

Photo: Getty Images

## Britain’s underperforming economy

Data released on Wednesday showed that Britain’s economy grew in January, but by a modest 0.2%. The update is the first since the news that a 0.1% month-on-month contraction in December pushed the economy into a technical recession. It has barely grown since the pandemic, and has performed less well than the euro zone and America.

Figures released the day before showed that the unemployment rate ticked up to 3.9% (from 3.8%) and that wage growth fell faster than expected. Inflation numbers are due next Wednesday. All this will guide the rate-setters at the Bank of England’s Monetary Policy Committee, which is due to meet next week. The MPC’s last vote was an unusual three-way split: members voted to raise rates, to lower them and to keep them steady. This division reflects economic trends that are in tension with each other: reasonably robust employment, falling (but still high) inflation and feeble growth.

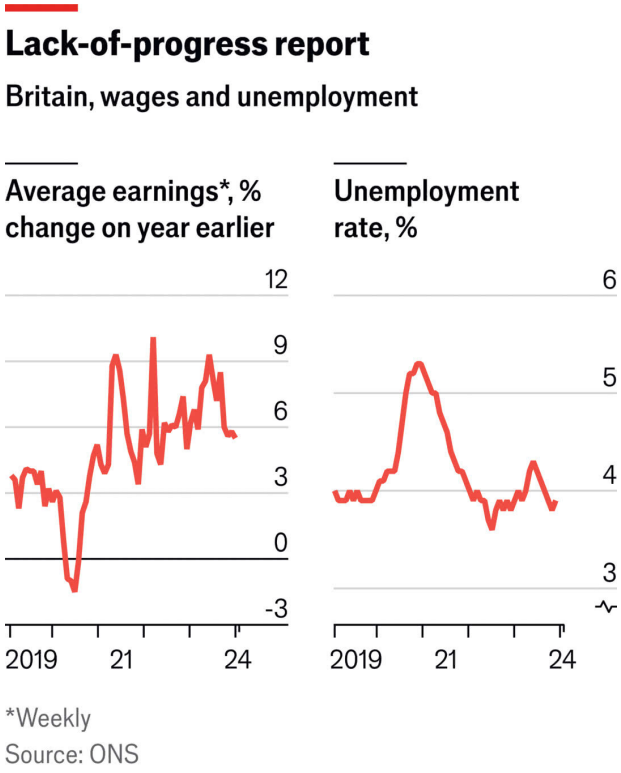

Photo: Reuters

## Germany’s missile saga continues

Germany’s Taurus cruise missiles boast exceptional accuracy, explosive force and range. They also pack the power to cause controversy. Olaf Scholz, the German chancellor, has for months dodged calls from allies abroad and political foes at home to deliver the weapons to Ukraine. But the issue always resurfaces.

On Wednesday he faces a grilling in Germany's parliament and on Thursday the opposition will table a motion to deliver Taurus.

That vote will probably not succeed, but nor will the missile saga end. Most Germans agree with Mr Scholz that, as Ukraine's second-biggest donor of military and financial aid after America, Germany is doing enough. But hawks say that "enough" would be giving Ukraine the means to beat Russia. The Taurus, a better version of systems France and Britain have already sent, would give Ukraine's beleaguered armed forces a welcome boost. The day may yet come when Mr Scholz sees the need for the missiles to stop flying in circles and instead land with a bang.

Photo: Getty Images

## High hopes for a fashion giant

The world's biggest fashion retailer, Inditex, publishes its earnings on Wednesday. The Spanish group—which owns both high-street brands (Zara) and upmarket ones (Massimo Dutti)—has been on a tear recently. Net profit reached €4.1bn ($4.4bn) in the nine months to October last year, an increase of nearly a third over the same period in 2022. Inditex has been gradually raising prices while keeping inventory low, getting garments from design to shelves in as little as a fortnight.

Not everything, however, has been going well. In December Zara caused uproars with adverts that seemed to show a mannequin in a white body bag amid rubble. Zara said that the pictures were misunderstood and were taken before Israel's offensive in Gaza. But it withdrew them anyway. The misstep doesn't seem to have hurt Inditex's share price, however. And on March 8th Ukraine's foreign ministry praised the firm for deciding to reopen most of the 84 stores it had closed following Russia's invasion.

Photo: Andrew Lawson

## Monet's garden blooms again

It is surely the most famous garden in art history. Claude Monet called the grounds of his house in Giverny, just west of Paris, his "most beautiful masterpiece". It was there that he produced his most celebrated series, "Water Lilies" (made up of 250 paintings), as well as renditions of irises and wisteria. Almost a century after Monet's death in 1926, half a million people visit Giverny every year.

A new exhibition at the Garden Museum in London shows how Monet turned the garden into a profusion of flowers and trees. After his son's death, however, Giverny fell into disrepair. Jean-Marie Toulgouat—who grew up in the village and was the great-

grandson of Monet's second wife—worked as an adviser on its restoration ahead of the reopening in 1980. Mr Toulgouat painted pictures of the garden at the same time. On display in London are his abstract renderings of dahlias, tulips and nasturtiums in bold strokes of colour. Some landscapes, it seems, demand a canvas.

## Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [email protected]. We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

**Wednesday:** Louis Philippe, King of France from 1830 to 1848, stemmed from which cadet branch of the Bourbon family?

**Tuesday:** Which is the largest of the Channel Islands, which sit between England and France?

*The instant is not in time—time is in the instant.*

*John Barbour*